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1

The 'atheism' of Christianity

Picture the scene: it's festival day in a provincial Roman city in the mid-second century AD, and people have come from far and wide to witness a group of local Christians being put to death. A young man called Germanicus stands in the arena, not just bravely facing savage beasts but actively urging them on. Irritated by the youth's composure, the crowd who have gathered to see him torn apart cry out: 'Down with the atheists!' Slightly later, the venerable bishop Polycarp is brought into the arena, and is ordered – on pain of death – to himself denounce his fellow Christians in the same way. Whereupon, we are told: 'Polycarp's brow darkened as he threw a look round the turbulent crowd of heathens in the circus; and then, indicating them with a sweep of his hand, he said with a growl and a glance to heaven "Down with the atheists!"' (*Martyrdom of Polycarp*, 9).[1]

St Polycarp, whom ancient tradition assures was a disciple of St John the Evangelist, was bishop of Smyrna (modern-day Izmir on the west coast of Turkey) for much of the first half of the second century. This gripping, eyewitness account of his and his companions' martyrdom around the year 156 is the earliest such report we have, and hence offers invaluable

1 The translation here (slightly amended) is taken from Maxwell Staniforth (trans.), 1968, *Early Christian Writings*, Harmondsworth: Penguin, pp. 153–67.

insights into ancient Christian life, thought and practice. For our purposes, the word translated as 'atheists' here is our old friend, *atheoi*. Given the context, its meaning here is rather more transparent than it was in Ephesians. In effect, we have the Christian Polycarp and the pagan crowd mutually denouncing each other as 'infidels'. As far as the crowd is concerned, the Christians deny and dishonour the *real* Roman gods, while affirming their own false one. (At one point, the arena crowd cry out that Polycarp is a 'destroyer of our gods, who is teaching whole multitudes to abstain from sacrificing to them or worshipping them' – *Martyrdom*, 12.) But as far as Polycarp is concerned, the crowd do precisely the opposite.

On one level, this is just an instance of a broad phenomenon noted in the Introduction, of 'atheist' being used throughout much of history as a term of abuse: it is always one's *enemies* who are the 'atheists' (and the feeling is often mutual). However, in the writings of St Justin Martyr, one of Polycarp's contemporaries, the same basic idea receives a somewhat different twist. Justin had himself been brought up a pagan, but in later life, having worked his way through a succession of different philosophies – Stoicism, Pythagoreanism, Aristotelianism and Platonism – he finally settled on Christianity as the 'true Philosophy'. Not incidentally, he was also impressed by the composure and dignity of the Christian martyrs: 'when I was delighting in [hearing] the Christians slandered, and saw them fearless of death, [I] perceived that it was impossible they could be living in wickedness and pleasure' (*Second Apology*, 11).[2]

2 This, and all other quotations from Justin's and Pseudo-Justin's (see below) writings, may be found in Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (eds), 1996, *The Ante-Nicene Fathers, Volume I: The Apostolic Fathers – Justin Martyr – Irenaeus*, Edinburgh: T & T Clark. These and a huge number of other translated texts from the early Church Fathers can also be found at: www.newadvent.org/fathers/.

Roughly a decade after Polycarp met his fate in Smyrna, Justin was himself martyred.

Along with several other second-century Christian thinkers, Justin wrote a number of *apologias* – 'defences' rather than 'apologies' in the usual meaning of the word (and the root of 'apologetics', or the rational defence of Christian doctrine) – in an attempt to explain what and why Christians believed for his pagan contemporaries, and to correct common misunderstandings about them. The charge of 'atheism' was one of these. Justin, however, novelly chooses to side with *both* Polycarp *and* the crowd, declaring in his *First Apology*: 'we confess that we are atheists, so far as gods of this sort [i.e. the Greco-Roman ones] are concerned, but not with respect to the Most True God' (*First Apology*, 6). For Justin then, there is at least one, albeit qualified, sense in which Christians are, and must be, atheists.

Justin is far from alone within the tradition in identifying forms of genuinely *Christian* 'atheism', by which I mean perfectly orthodox forms and varieties of 'atheism' within Christianity. Some of these are stronger than others, but all arguably deserve the name 'atheism', albeit in a subtle and not-to-be-read-naively sort of way (hence inverted commas flag up the genuine, if qualified, deployment of the word).[3] While the rest of this book will concern itself with the theology of what one might call atheism proper (i.e. atheism as the absence of belief in a God or gods, understood in the

3 These should not, however, be confused with what one might call forms of 'Christian' *atheism*. I include the various attempts by certain western twentieth-century theologians to affirm the 'death of God' while retaining Christian rituals, language and – often enough – jobs. These fads were, mercifully enough, short-lived. After all, it is rather the point of Christianity that its dead God has a habit of not staying so for very long.

normal way, and hence unadorned by quotation marks), it will be a fruitful and hopefully interesting prelude to consider instead the 'atheism' of proper theology. We will find ourselves in good company: Paul, Justin Martyr, Augustine, Meister Eckhart, Herbert McCabe, John of the Cross and Mother Teresa will all be joining us on our adventure.

God and 'the gods'

The first move for us to make here is to consider more deeply Justin's above quoted remark: 'we confess that we are atheists, so far as gods of this sort are concerned, but not with respect to the Most True God'. Justin's point here is to drive a wedge between the false, so-called 'gods' of the Roman world – e.g. 'we not only deny that they. . . are gods, but assert that they are wicked and impious demons' (*First Apology*, 5) – and the authentic *God* whom Christians proclaim as Lord. This point is made more explicit in another (and perhaps also second-century) text, sometimes ascribed to Justin himself but now considered more likely to be the work of a Justin-inspired disciple. For Pseudo-Justin – as he has come to be known – this 'true and invariable Name' (*On the Sole Government of God*, 6) is only correctly 'applicable to the only true God' (*Government*, 1). Any others given the name, including those whom the pagans *call* gods, receive it unworthily. Hence referring to Greco-Roman mythology, he speaks dismissively of 'those who think that they shall share the holy and perfect Name, which some have received by a vain tradition as if they were gods' (*Government*, 5).

A very similar idea, although expressed slightly differently, appears in the New Testament in 1 Corinthians 8.

In the course of giving practical advice on the eating of food sacrificed to idols, Paul also distinguishes between the 'so-called gods in heaven or on earth' and the 'one God' (8.5–6). Paul seems to oscillate between implying that these so-called gods are simple fictions ('no idol in the world really exists') and affirming that though real enough in themselves, these 'many gods and many lords' certainly do not deserve to share the divine name. But regardless of whether they are demons or mere figments, Paul's basic point is clear: 'for us there is one God, the Father, from whom are all things and for whom we exist, and one Lord, Jesus Christ, through whom all things are and through whom we exist' (1 Cor. 8.4–6).

For Paul, as for Justin, Christians must therefore be atheists regarding 'the gods'. And nor is this merely an academic, highfalutinly theological point for him. Rather, he is anxious that the Corinthians be vigilant against lapsing, or inadvertently causing others to lapse, into idolatry – that is, into the offering of worship due to 'the Most True God' to those who are falsely so-called. Recent converts, in particular, might be fooled into thinking that 'the gods', though falsely so-called, are actually deserving of the name: 'Since some have become so accustomed to idols until now, they still think of the food they eat as offered to an idol; and their conscience, being weak, is defiled' (8.7). (Still, heartenningly perhaps, this suggests that crises of catechesis are not a new phenomenon within the Church.) Hence, lest the practice of eating food sacrificed to idols, though in itself innocuous enough, become 'a stumbling-block to the weak', Paul advises against it. Better to go without cheap meat than to confuse others about the distinction between the misnamed 'gods' and the Most – and, for that matter, *only* – True one.

God, falsely so-called

As far as Pseudo-Justin is concerned, the word 'God' is not a description of something but is rather a proper name. For him, the classical gods and goddesses – Zeus, Hera, Hermes, Aphrodite and the rest – are imposters. They are not gods at all but are masquerading under a false name and an assumed identity.

Let us agree with Pseudo-Justin that, for Christians, *God* is first and foremost the name of someone: a someone quite unlike any other someone, it is true, but a someone (or somethree?) nonetheless. Though we may, on occasion, use the word as though it were primarily a description or definition – e.g. 'God, *noun*, an omnipotent, omniscient, omnibenevolent, Creator of the universe' – this does not affect the basic point. Pseudo-Justin assumes, however, that the use of 'God', *theos* in Greek, as a name for the Jews' and Christians' 'Sovereign Lord, who made the heaven and the earth, the sea, and everything in them' (Acts 4.24), somehow precedes the use of 'god' as a description for a class of vastly inferior, supernatural beings domiciled on Mount Olympus. In truth, however, the original borrowing was almost certainly the other way around: Hellenized Jews stealing as a name for Yahweh the already existing Greek descriptive noun *theos*. As such, a converse case can be made for arguing that it is the Judeo-Christian *God* who is falsely, or at least misleadingly, so-called. If so, then Christians 'proclaim ourselves atheists' in a still deeper sense than Justin himself envisages.

This is a point that the twentieth-century Anglo-Irish Dominican theologian Herbert McCabe – a hugely, though subtly, influential figure on much of the best Anglophone theology of the past several decades – was at pains to stress.

To quote a characteristic passage from *God Still Matters*, a posthumous collection of his essays and sermons:

> We do not know what we are talking about when we use the word 'God' . . . When Jews and Christians came to use the word 'god' it was already lying around meaning something else – I mean it meant something that God certainly could not be, a god. Whatever we are referring to when we use the word 'God' it can no more be a god than it can be a model aeroplane or half-past eleven.[4]

This idea is fleshed out more fully in a different essay, slightly earlier in the book:

> 'God', 'Theos', 'Deus' is of course a name borrowed from paganism; we take it out of its proper context, where it is used for talking about the gods, and use it for our own purposes. This is quite a legitimate piece of borrowing and quite safe as long as it does not mislead us into thinking that the God we worship (or don't) is a god . . . He is always dressed verbally in second-hand clothes that don't fit him very well. We always have to be on our guard against taking these clothes as revealing who or what he is.[5]

What McCabe is doing here is effectively turning Pseudo-Justin's argument on its head. He points out that, in its original context, 'god' (*theos*) denotes a class of personal, superhuman, supernatural beings, who collectively possess

4 Herbert McCabe, 2002, *God Still Matters*, ed. Brian Davies, London: Continuum, p. 55.
5 McCabe, *God Still Matters*, p. 3.

a wide range of impressive, though limited, super powers. Now, as a *description* of the One worshipped and glorified by the ancient Israelites, and thus latterly the early Christians too, that is a fairly awful one. To give just one example: while Zeus, Hera and Aphrodite may well be very powerful (and vastly more powerful than any human), they are still things *within* the universe. By contrast, the 'God of Abraham, and of Jacob' is considered to be the all-powerful creator and sustainer of the universe *itself*.

But by choosing to refer to this One with the word 'god', Greek-speaking Jews – including, most influentially, those translating the Hebrew Scriptures – were using it as a name, rather than as a literal description. Transferred to this new context, the proper noun *God* became a kind of metaphor. There is a sense in which God is *like* a 'god' (he too is powerful, for example, albeit both far more so, and in a qualitatively different way), just as there is a sense in which God is *like* 'a mighty fortress' (he is steadfast, and protects those who 'dwell within' him). But the Judeo-Christian God cannot be an actual mighty fortress. And he cannot be, as McCabe reminds us, an actual 'god'.

This point may perhaps be more easily grasped if one considers a couple giving their daughter the name of 'Poppy'. They may have many reasons for doing so. Possibly it is a family name, or a tribute to a cantankerous Liverpudlian cat from the children's television of their childhood. It may simply be because they like the sound of the word. Feasibly, however, there is something about *actual* poppies that makes them think it would be a fitting name for a daughter: their beauty, or gracefulness, for example. Perhaps, due to some small but fondly remembered moment in their lives, poppies make the couple smile – and they think this will be true of their Poppy too. They are not, of course,

using this word as a straightforward description: she is not, and will not be, an actual member of the botanical family *Papaveraceae*. Instead, the word functions as a kind of metaphor or analogy: by naming her thus, her parents are intimating that they think (or hope) she will be like a poppy *in some way*. Seen objectively, this link may seem somewhat tenuous. There will, after all, be vastly more ways in which the child is not at all like a poppy, than there are ways in which she is: she won't photosynthesize, she won't be a symbol of Remembrance Sunday, she won't be a major ingredient in the production of heroin . . . But nevertheless, there *is* a link, however slight, and one that is, to her parents at least, a significant one.

Naturally, there is no danger whatsoever of anyone in their right mind mistaking this Poppy's metaphorical name for a literal description, as my silly examples above are intended to show. Yet, as McCabe points out, and as Paul and Pseudo-Justin were all too aware, such is not the case with the Christian God. While he may have some points of contact with the Olympian gods, he is not, and could not be, simply a superpowerful 'thing' within the universe: 'Whatever we are referring to when we use the word "God" it can no more be a god than it can be a model aeroplane or half-past eleven.' To think otherwise – to suppose that God is simply a 'god', even if the biggest and best one of them all – is to commit idolatry. And this is, moreover, a point that applies far more widely. Without delving too deeply here into a very fraught and complex area, suffice it to say that it is not just the word 'god' that, if mistaken as a literal description, comes insultingly short. Certainly, a strong case can be made that *all* human words about the Most True God are condemned to be egregiously lacking. Witness, for example, St Augustine's comment on our use

of the word 'person' – a stalwart of orthodox trinitarian theology since at least the early third century – as a description for the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit:

> Because the Father is not the Son, and the Son is not the Father, and the Holy Spirit . . . is neither the Father nor the Son, then certainly there are three . . . But when it is asked 'Three what?' then the great poverty from which our language suffers becomes apparent. But the formula 'three persons' has been coined, not in order to give a complete explanation by means of it, but in order that we might not be obliged to remain silent. (*On the Trinity*, 5.10)[6]

On arguably similar lines, the thirteenth-century German Dominican theologian Meister Eckhart writes in one of his vernacular sermons: 'let us pray to God that we may be free of God that we may gain the truth and enjoy it eternally.'[7] Quite how this cryptic saying should be understood is a matter of controversy. Eckhart was never one to shy away from verbal pyrotechnics, and his daring and ambiguous phrasing of fundamentally orthodox ideas both landed him in hot water in his own times, and guaranteed him a wildly diverse array of aficionados in subsequent centuries. (Few medieval theologians can claim a list of twentieth-century devotees that is at once so impressive and so dubious as the following: the Marxist philosopher Ernst Bloch, the New Age guru Eckhart Tolle, the Nobel Peace Prize-winning statesman

6 Quoted from Gerald O'Collins, 1999, *The Tripersonal God: Understanding and Interpreting the Trinity*, Mahwah, NJ: Paulist Press, p. 141.

7 Quoted from Maurice Walshe (trans.), 2009, *The Complete Mystical Works of Meister Eckhart*, New York: Crossroad, p. 422.

Dag Hammarskjöld, the experimental composer John Cage and the Nazi war criminal Alfred Rosenberg.) One plausible interpretation, however, is that Eckhart is drawing a distinction here between the Most True God ('let us pray to God'), and our flawed human conceptions of who that God actually is ('that we may be free of "god"'), in the interests both of truth and salvation ('that we may gain the truth and enjoy it eternally'). On this reading, Eckhart's utterance is radical enough to be fully orthodox, and a further instance of the kind of theological 'atheism' we have divined in the writings of Paul, Justin, Pseudo-Justin and McCabe. For all of them, the worship of false 'gods' in whatever form – whether Olympian super-things, demons, fictions, or naive theological constructions – amounts to the same: idol worship. Hence in the words of McCabe:

> The worship of [the] Creator is the only worship worthy of a human being . . . This, you might say, was the great Hebrew discovery: human beings are such that they worship *only* the mystery by which there is anything at all instead of nothing . . . [T]he human being is now defined, if you like, as the Creator-worshipper, the atheist with no gods to worship, no gods to petition, no gods to pray to, no gods worth praying to.[8]

'Only an atheist can be a good Christian'

The Marxist philosopher Ernst Bloch, in his rich and remarkable 1972 book *Atheism in Christianity*, famously observed:

8 McCabe, *God Still Matters*, p. 56.

'Only an atheist can be a good Christian; only a Christian can be a good atheist.'[9] More recently, the Slovenian intellectual Slavoj Žižek writes: 'not only is *Christianity* (at its core, if disavowed by its institutional practice) *the only truly consistent atheism*, it is also that *atheists are the only true believers*.'[10] Bloch and Žižek are both atheists by our definition, at least in the 'negative' sense of being without a belief in the existence of a God or gods, and the points they are making here are largely political and ethical. For example, Bloch firmly believed that 'the Bible has always been the Church's bad conscience',[11] and he stands out among Marxist theorists for giving due attention to Marx's own observation that the working classes' religious yearnings are, among other things, a *protest* against unjust social conditions. (That's the bit of the 'religion is the opium of the masses' passage that people tend to overlook.) Broadly similar ideas can, however, be found in the works of influential Christian writers also. So far in this chapter we have focused on the 'atheism' of Christianity, albeit in a carefully qualified, subtle, though nonetheless significant, sense of the word: an 'atheism' regarding the 'gods', but not an atheism regarding *God*. The obvious flipside to this is a consideration of the ways in which atheism, and indeed atheists, might have points of contact with these forms of Christian (non)believing.

In the theological literature on atheism, it is possible to identify two main tendencies along these kinds of line. The first is quite negative, and dismisses atheistic ideas and

9 Ernst Bloch, 1972, *Atheism in Christianity*, trans. J. T. Swann, New York: Herder & Herder, p. 9.

10 Slavoj Žižek, 2012, *Less Than Nothing: Hegel and the Shadow of Dialectical Materialism*, London: Verso, p. 116 (emphasis in original).

11 Bloch, *Atheism in Christianity*, p. 21.

arguments as being, at best, obvious and platitudinous, and at worst, wholly beside the point. The conceptions of God that atheists deny have, it is claimed, no bearing at all on the God in whom Christians actually believe: such 'so-called gods' are naive and idolatrous caricatures, and Christian thinkers have *already* made short (and rather more sophisticated) work of dismissing them in their strivings to apprehend the Most True God. For example, Denys Turner teases atheists for trumpeting as hard-won conclusions what their theological counterparts take to be nothing more than basic and unremarkable premises:

> [I]n the sense in which atheists of this sort say God 'does not exist', that atheist has merely arrived at the theological starting-point. Theologians of the classical traditions, an Augustine, a Thomas Aquinas or a Meister Eckhart, simply agree about the disposing of idolatries, and then proceed with the proper business of doing theology.[12]

The second tendency, meanwhile, takes the same basic point, but gives it a rather more positive spin. On this view, the atheist is cast as the anti-idolater *par excellence*, rejecting all (mis)conceptions of both God and the gods wholesale, and being, at least for the most part, right to do so: 'atheism properly and effectively criticizes false and misleading images of God'.[13] After all, so this argument sometimes goes, *all* human ideas about God must necessarily fall short of him. This is, as we have seen, the insight of such exemplary Christians thinkers as Augustine and Eckhart. In

12 Denys Turner, 2002, *Faith Seeking*, London: SCM Press, p. 8.

13 Étienne Borne, 1961, *Modern Atheism*, trans. S. J. Testier, London: Burns & Oates, p. 144.

its strongest expressions, this strand of Christian thought (sometimes called negative or apophatic theology), as it may be found in the writings of the enigmatic but influential fourth- or fifth-century writer known as Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite, asserts that whatever it is that Christians call God, 'It falls neither within the predicate of nonbeing nor of being . . . It is beyond assertion and denial.'[14] And if this is the case, then aren't atheists on to something very profound – and authentically Christian – after all?

Evidence of both these two tendencies occurs in the writings of the Russian novelist Fyodor Dostoevsky. As well as being one of the great geniuses of world literature, Dostoevsky is widely recognized as among the nineteenth century's most profound theological thinkers. His wide-ranging and nuanced engagement with atheism, motivated and informed by his personal grapplings with the subject – he once admitted that his own 'hosanna' had passed through 'a furnace of doubt' – is a case in point. More will be said about it in the following chapter in relation to the problem of suffering and evil. But for our purposes here, note the remark by the saintly Prince Myshkin, the protagonist of Dostoevsky's 1868 novel *The Idiot*, that 'there's something in [true religious feeling] that atheisms eternally glance off, and they will eternally be talking *not about that*.'[15] For Myshkin, atheists are condemned always to 'miss the point' when discussing God and religion: in our terminology, their criticisms of 'god' are irrelevant to

14 Quoted from Colm Luibhéid and Paul Rorem (eds and trans.), 1987, *Pseudo-Dionysius: The Complete Works*, Mahwah, NJ: Paulist Press, p. 141.

15 Fyodor Dostoevsky, [1868] 2001, *The Idiot*, trans. Richard Pevear and Larissa Volokhonsky, London: Granta, p. 221.

the Most True one. This is, of course, an instance of the negative, dismissive tendency we noted above.

However, compare the following from a slightly later novel, 1872's *Demons*. Here the Orthodox bishop Tikhon tells the unbeliever Stavrogin: 'A complete atheist stands on the next-to-last upper step to the most complete faith.'[16] Here we see our second tendency in one of its boldest expressions. For Tikhon, the 'complete atheist' is one who has rejected every single false 'god', including everything and anything that takes, or tries to take, the rightful place of the true God (or to quote again the words of Pseudo-Justin: 'those who think that they shall share the holy and perfect Name, which some have received by a vain tradition as if they were gods'). Such a purified position, which Tikhon places higher than all 'incomplete' forms of faith – and thus, one assumes, above the faith of the vast majority of believers, past, present and future – is thus lacking only one thing.

Two things are worth noting here. Tikhon speaks of 'complete' atheism and 'complete' faith, with the presumable implication that very few atheists are so completely, just as very few believers – i.e. the saints – are so completely. The suggestion is, perhaps, that the great majority of atheists aren't as thoroughgoing as they might like to think. Tikhon does not expand upon this point, though the lacuna here may perhaps be supplied by McCabe, for whom a 'false god' is anything in which we mistakenly place our trust and worship:

16 Fyodor Dostoevsky, [1872] 2000, *Demons*, trans. Richard Pevear and Larissa Volokhonsky, New York: Everyman: p. 668.

> It would be tedious to list the well-known gods of this exceptionally superstitious twentieth century. Quite apart from surviving old ones like astrology, there are a lot of new ones like racism, nationalism, the Market, the Leader . . . you name it.[17]

Also worthy of comment is Tikhon's choice of metaphor. Envisioning the Christian spiritual life as a series of ascending steps, or perhaps ladder rungs, is relatively common, especially in Eastern Orthodoxy. But viewed from this perspective, 'the most complete atheism' isn't simply next-best to the 'most complete faith'. Instead it is a prerequisite for it: a stage that all those seeking complete faith must pass through en route. This is a notion that we shall return to presently.

Both of these tendencies, in Dostoevsky as elsewhere, provide us with considerable food for thought. And at least to some degree, both seem to have something going for them. Regarding the first one, it is surely true that positive atheists often reject specific conceptions of God that, frankly, do not pass muster in classical Christian theology. And regarding the second one, it has been the dominant theme of this chapter that there can indeed be authentically Christian forms of anti-idolatrous 'atheism'. But – at least in their bolder and least qualified expressions – both tendencies arguably tell us far more about Christian theology than they do about actual atheists. Regarding the former, let us accept that most unbelievers aren't especially well acquainted with the minutiae of the Christian doctrine of God. The same is unquestionably true of a great many pious, practising, faith-*and*-works Christian believers.

17 McCabe, *God Still Matters*, p. 32.

Theologians are, needless to say, rather slower off the mark to deride the conceptions of God in which they (explicitly) believe, or think they do, than they are to do the same to the conceptions of God in which many atheists do not. Let us note, too, an idea that will be a major theme of Chapter 3: if the typical discourse about God really is so woefully ill-informed, then is that not at least partly the fault of Christians themselves?

Furthermore, while there may well be a certain correlation between atheism and negative theology (and one that we have been gleefully exploiting in this chapter), it is surely rather a stretch to identify the two too closely. For all of McCabe's and Justin's legitimate distinction between *God* and 'the gods', and for all of Pseudo-Dionysius' awareness of the difficulties of trying to say something about this reality that doesn't fall infinitely and insultingly short of it, the fact remains that, unlike atheists, Christians do indeed affirm the existence of God – and a God whose name, howsoever metaphorically and requiring of qualification, does indeed convey at least something of significance about him (just as Poppy's name does of her). So while it is true to say that there is a sense in which Christians are indeed 'atheists' (regarding mere 'gods'), it does not follow conversely that all unbelievers are but apophatic theologians of a Pseudo-Dionysian bent. For they, atheists *sans* inverted commas, are without a belief in the existence, not only of gods but of the Most True God as well.

'The deeper the darkness'

So far in this chapter, we have focused on what one could call intellectual or theological types of 'atheism' in Christianity:

insistences that, one way or another, Christians worship 'the God who is not a god'.[18] However, there is another, and arguably more significant, kind within the Christian tradition: the experiential 'atheism' of some of the mystics. As before, the word is used here in a sense rather different from atheism's usual one. Yet there is enough contact between the normal meaning, and our heavily qualified, 'inverted-commas' usage, to justify the calculated risk of serious misunderstanding. It need hardly be said that John of the Cross, Mother Teresa, Padre Pio and even Jesus himself – all figures to whom we shall refer below – were not atheists in the term's normal meaning. Nevertheless, the experiences of 'godforsakenness' that all underwent – while, it should be stressed, wholly foreign to the vast majority of normal atheists – are certainly worthy of comment in a chapter with a title such as this. This is, however, a huge topic in its own right: *The Absence of God in the Lives of the Saints* would make for a very fine, though very long, book. As such, only some brief remarks are possible here.

According to the Gospels, Christ cried out from the Cross the opening lines of Psalm 22: 'My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?' (Mark 15.31). In the words' original context, the Psalmist's despair leads on to an affirmation of the Lord's victorious constancy. Within the wider context of Easter, the same is true here as well. But that need not mean, on that particular Friday afternoon, that Jesus intended them with anything less than full sincerity. By the medieval period, these crucial words of Christ's came to be deeply significant among Christian mystics identifying with the sufferings of the Cross. In the medieval period, for example, influential figures such as Blessed Angela of Foligno

18 McCabe, *God Still Matters*, p. 32.

(1248–1309), St Mechthild of Magdeburg (*c.* 1210–*c.* 1285) and Blessed Margaret Ebner (1291–1351) reported periods of feeling abandoned by God. Quoting the latter's experience, for instance: 'my Lord Jesus Christ placed me in such indescribable misery and a feeling of abandonment that it seemed as if I had never experienced the grace of our Lord in my whole life. I had completely lost trust in his mercy.'[19] Two and a half centuries later, such episodes would receive their classic crystallization as 'the dark night of the soul' of the Spanish poet-theologian St John of the Cross:

> When this purgative contemplation oppresses a man, he feels very vividly indeed the shadow of death, the sighs of death, and the sorrows of hell, all of which reflect the feeling of God's absence, of being chastised and rejected by Him, and of being unworthy of Him, as well as the object of his anger. The soul experiences all this and even more, for now it seems that this affliction will last forever.[20]

Without supposing them all to be the same in either nature or source, experiences like these have been reported by many leading figures in the Christian tradition (as well as by a great many other people, Christians and not too). Witness the Italian stigmatist Padre Pio, for example, writing in 1918:

19 Quoted in Bernard McGinn, 1998, *The Flowering of Mysticism: Men and Women in the New Mysticism (1200–1350)*, New York: Crossroad Herder, p. 241.

20 Kieran Kavanaugh and Otilio Rodriguez (eds and trans.), 1966, *The Collected Works of St. John of the Cross*, London: Thomas Nelson, p. 338.

> I keep my eyes fixed on the East in the night which surrounds me, to discover that miraculous star which guided our forebears to the Grotto of Bethlehem. But I strain my eyes in vain to see that luminary rise in the heavens . . . The more I fix my gaze the dimmer my sight becomes . . . the deeper the darkness which envelopes me. I am alone by day and night and no ray of light comes through to enlighten me.[21]

Dostoevsky, too, seems not to have been a stranger to such episodes. When viewing Hans Holbein's *Dead Christ in the Tomb* – a full-size, horizontal painting of his wounded and rigor-mortising cadaver – at the gallery in Basel, his wife reports that he stood transfixed, and seemed on the verge of an epileptic seizure.[22] And to these we might also add the Catholic saints Thérèse of Lisieux, Paul of the Cross and Gemma Galgani.

John of the Cross aside, perhaps the most famous sufferer of such spiritual desolation is Mother Teresa of Calcutta, foundress of the Missionaries of Charity and recipient of the Nobel Prize for Peace in 1979. Her 40 years of near-constant 'darkness', thirsting for the God who had once felt so near (and sometimes, rarely and fleetingly, did still), were only fully revealed with the publication of her private writings in 2007. Among the many, harrowing descriptions she gives of it, the following is perhaps the most detailed (with her own distinctive punctuation style intact):

21 Quoted in C. Bernard Ruffin, 1991, *Padre Pio: The True Story*, Huntington, IN: Our Sunday Visitor, pp. 149–50.

22 See Malcolm Muggeridge, 2011, *The Gospel in Dostoyevsky: Selections from his Writings*, Rifton, NY: Plough, pp. vi–vii.

> Darkness is such that I really do not see – neither with my mind nor with my reason. – The place of God in my soul is blank. – There is no God in me. – When the pain of longing is so great – I just long & long for God – and then it is that I feel – He does not want me – He is not there . . . Sometimes – I just hear my own heart cry out – 'My God' and nothing else comes. – The torture and pain I can't explain . . . I long for God – I want to love Him – to love Him much – to live only for love of Him – to love only – and yet there is but pain – longing and no love.[23]

Given statements such as these, it is not at all surprising that Teresa's revelations were widely interpreted as proof of her having been an atheist, pure and simple (and thus, naturally, a hypocrite). But, of course, things are not nearly so simple. While one can indeed speak here of an *experiential* 'atheism' – the 'atheism' of one who acutely, and painfully, perceives God's seeming absence – this is plainly not atheism in any simple or straightforward sense of the word. In the above quotation, apparently atheistic statements are set alongside, and hence qualified by, expressions of abiding trust and abandonment to the One who seems so absent. This is even clearer in those statements of her darkness that are, unmistakably, written as prayers. Consider, for example:

> So many unanswered questions live within me – I am afraid to uncover them – because of the blasphemy . . .

23 Quoted in Brian Kolodiejchuk (ed.), 2008, *Mother Teresa: Come Be My Light: The Revealing Private Writings of the Nobel Peace Prize Winner*, London: Rider, p. 210.

> When I try to raise my thoughts to Heaven – there is such convicting emptiness that those very thoughts return like sharp knives & hurt my soul . . . If this brings You glory, if You get a drop of joy from this – if souls are brought to You – if my suffering satiates Your Thirst – here I am Lord, with joy I accept all to the end of life – & I will smile at Your Hidden Face – always.[24]

Just as Justin's affirmation of the Most True God qualifies and explains his acceptance of the label 'atheist', so too do Teresa's *prayers* concerning her lack of faith undermine any identification of her as an actual atheist. (Except in our duly qualified and orthodox sense of the word.) And as with other figures in the Christian tradition, it was precisely Teresa's feeling of abandonment that proved the catalyst for her ever-deepening faith in, and service to, Christ. The two hallmarks of her spirituality, devotion to the Eucharist and devotion to the destitute, stem from her longing to be in Christ's presence. Taking Scripture at its word on both counts – 'This is my body' (Mark 14.22) and 'Just as you did it to one of the least of my brother, you did it to me' (Matt. 25.40) – she sought to fill the void of his absence at the level of her felt experience. In a rather different, but no less significant, way from Justin, she thus sought and found the Most True God.

Conclusion

The purpose of this opening chapter was intentionally provocative: to show the ways in which 'atheism' – although

24 Kolodiejchuk, pp. 187–8.

not-atheism in the normal sense – sits close to the heart of classical Christian theology and spirituality. To a certain degree, this helps us to see some of the points of constructive contact between faith and unbelief. For example, atheists' critiques can indeed aid us in purifying our ever-faulty notions of 'the God who is not a god'. But it should also help us to guard against naive claims as to the alleged affinities between genuine atheism and authentic Christianity. It will be an abiding theme of this book that the difference between faith and unbelief – between following, howsoever falteringly, the Most True God, and not – is indeed one of mighty significance.